Hope Hospital **Creation Date** **01/01/2017** **Released Date** **11/01/2017**	**Guidelines on dispensing of medications**	
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1. Purpose

To ensure safe, accurate, and timely dispensing of medications to patients while minimizing errors and ensuring compliance with legal and institutional policies.

2. Scope

Applicable to all pharmacy personnel involved in dispensing medications within the healthcare facility.

3. Responsibilities

- Dispensing pharmacists and pharmacy technicians must adhere to all dispensing protocols.
- Verify all prescriptions for completeness, clarity, and legality before dispensing.

4. Prescription Verification

- Confirm the prescription is written by an authorized prescriber.

- Check patient details, drug name (preferably generic), dose, route, frequency, and duration.
- Identify potential drug interactions, allergies, contraindications, and duplicates.
- Clarify any ambiguities with the prescriber before dispensing.

5. Dispensing Process

- Use a clean and organized dispensing area free from distractions.
- Prepare and label medications accurately with:
    - Patient name
    - Drug name and strength
    - Dosage instructions in clear, understandable language
    - Quantity supplied
    - Date of dispensing
    - Expiry date and batch number (if applicable)
- Use standard measurement devices for liquids.
- Ensure packaging maintains drug stability and integrity.
- Provide medication leaflets or counseling as needed.

6. Patient Counseling

- Explain dosage schedule, route, duration, and storage.
- Inform about possible side effects and what to do if they occur.
- Advise on missed doses and drug interactions (food, other drugs).
- Encourage patients to ask questions.
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7. Documentation and Record-Keeping

- Maintain records of all dispensed medications including prescription copy, date, and dispenser's identity.
- Ensure controlled substances are recorded as per regulatory requirements.

8. Handling Errors

- Immediately report and document any dispensing errors or near misses.
- Take corrective action and inform the patient and prescriber as necessary.

9. Storage and Inventory Management

- Store medications as per manufacturer's guidelines (temperature, humidity, light).
- Regularly check stock for expiry and damaged items.
- Follow FIFO (First In, First Out) for stock rotation.

10. Legal and Regulatory Compliance

- Comply with applicable drug laws and regulations.
- Ensure only licensed personnel dispense medications.
- Handle controlled substances with additional care and documentation.

11. Training and Quality Assurance

- Regular training for pharmacy staff on safe dispensing practices.
- Periodic audits and quality checks as part of hospital's medication safety program.